

Chapter 6: Too Familiar to Ignore

Jenny told herself it meant nothing.

People said things.

Customers flirted.

Wealthy men got bored.

That was all it was.

Still, three days passed.

And Austin Blackwood did not return.

At first, she felt relief.

Less tension.

Less arguing.

Less of that strange pressure in her chest when he looked at her too long.

By the second day, she told herself she didn't care.

By the third day...

She noticed.

Too much.

"Jenny, table four!" Bao called.

"I know!" she snapped automatically.

Then immediately sighed.

She hadn't meant to sound irritated.

She just hadn't slept well.

That was all.

Nothing else.

The lunch rush moved like usual.

Trays.

Orders.

Noise.

Steam rising from the kitchen.

Normal.

Safe.

Predictable.

But Jenny kept glancing at the door.

She hated herself for it.

"Looking for someone?" Bao teased.

"No."

"Then why do you keep checking the entrance?"

"I'm checking customers."

Bao smirked.

"Sure you are."

Jenny grabbed a tray harder than necessary.

"I don't care who walks in that door."

"Uh-huh."

The bell above the entrance rang.

Jenny didn't look.

Not immediately.

She refused to.

"Table seven," Madam Chen called.

Jenny turned.

Walked.

Smiled.

Worked.

Normal.

Then she stopped.

Her steps slowed.

Her breath caught slightly.

Because there he was.

Austin Blackwood.

Standing near the entrance like he had never left.

Like he belonged there.

Like he had always been there.

Jenny blinked once.

Twice.

Then walked closer.

"What are you doing here?" she asked.

Austin looked at her calmly.

"Eating."

"Obviously."

A pause.

"Again."

"Yes."

Jenny stared at him.

"You were gone for three days."

"I was busy."

"With what? The economy?"

That earned the smallest flicker of amusement in his eyes.

"I had meetings."

"Of course you did."

He didn't sit immediately.

Instead, he looked around the restaurant.

As if checking something.

Or someone.

Then finally, he said,

"Table by the window."

Same table.

Again.

Jenny crossed her arms.

"You always sit there."

"It's a good view."

"Of what? Poor people working?"

His gaze snapped back to her.

But instead of irritation, something else appeared.

Recognition.

"You think everything I do is judgmental."

"Isn't it?"

A pause.

Then, unexpectedly,

"No."

That stopped her.

Not his answer.

The way he said it.

Simple.

Direct.

Certain.

Jenny narrowed her eyes.

"You're weird today."

"I'm always the same."

"No," she said. "You're not."

That made him pause.

Just for a moment.

Then he sat down.

Jenny should have walked away.

She didn't.

Instead, she took his order.

Same dish.

Same tea.

Same calm voice.

But something felt different.

Smaller.

Closer.

Like a habit forming.

When she brought the food, Austin didn't look at the menu.

He looked at her.

"You're tired."

Jenny froze slightly.

"I'm fine."

"You didn't sleep."

"I slept."

"You didn't."

She placed the bowl down a little too hard.

"Are you always like this?"

"Like what?"

"Observing people like you're doing a financial audit."

That almost made him smile.

Almost.

"I notice patterns," he said.

"I am not a pattern."

A beat.

"You are becoming one."

That sentence lingered.

Jenny hated that it did.

She turned away quickly.

Too quickly.

Work continued.

But now she was aware of him.

Every time she passed his table.

Every time he lifted his cup.

Every time he looked up.

He was there.

Present.

Not loud.

Not demanding.

Just... consistent.

Like a fixed point in a chaotic day.

When the lunch rush ended, Jenny expected him to leave.

He didn't.

Instead, he stayed.

Reading.

Working.

Like the restaurant was just another office.

Bao leaned in.

"He's still here."

"I can see that."

"He's never stayed this long."

Jenny frowned.

"So?"

Bao grinned.

"So... that means something."

"It means he's slow at eating."

Bao laughed.

But Jenny didn't.

Because she had noticed something else.

He kept looking up.

Not at the door.

Not at the menu.

At her.

Each time she passed.

Each time she moved.

Each time she spoke to another customer.

Like she was the thing he was tracking.

And that made her uncomfortable.

And worse...

A little aware of herself.

Eventually, Austin stood.

Jenny pretended not to notice.

He walked to the counter.

Placed payment.

Then paused.

"Jenny."

She looked up.

"Yes?"

A beat.

"I'll see you tomorrow."

It wasn't a question.

It wasn't a threat.

It wasn't even a promise.

It was just a statement.

Like it was already decided.

Jenny frowned.

"You don't know that."

Austin met her eyes.

"I do."

Then he left.

The bell above the door rang softly behind him.

Jenny stood still.

Bao leaned over the counter.

"That is not normal behavior."

Jenny exhaled slowly.

"No," she said.

"It's not."

But even as she said it...

She already knew something had changed.

Because for the first time...

She wasn't surprised at all that he came back.

She was starting to expect it.